



▲ OLIVE OIL

Olives are grown across the Mediterranean. They are pressed to produce olive oil, an essential part of Italian cuisine.

Italy



Area 116,305 sq miles
(301,230 sq km)
Population 60.8 million
Capital Rome
Currency Euro
Official language Italian
Life expectancy 81 years

Italy is a boot-shaped peninsula that stretches southward into the Mediterranean Sea. It is bordered by the Alps to the north. Italy includes Sicily, Sardinia, and other smaller islands. The two famous volcanoes, Vesuvius and Etna, are located in southern Italy. A world leader in industrial and product design and textiles, Italy is also home to many prestigious fashion houses.

San Marino



Area 23.6 sq miles
(61 sq km)
Population 32,000
Capital San Marino
Currency Euro
Official language Italian
Life expectancy 82 years

A small nation lying within Italy, San Marino is perched around the slopes of Monte Titano in the Appennine Mountains. San Marino is the world's oldest republic. It is entirely dependent on Italy, which controls most of its affairs. The people of San Marino are called the Sammarinese. About one-third of them live in the northern town of Serravalle.

France



Area 211,209 sq miles
(547,030 sq km)
Population 63.1 million
Capital Paris
Currency Euro
Official language French
Life expectancy 81 years

France straddles western Europe from the English Channel to the Mediterranean Sea. It borders Germany and Belgium in the north, and Spain in the south. France was Europe's first modern republic, and once had a colonial empire second only to the British Empire. Today, it is one of the world's major industrial powers, as well as Europe's leading agricultural producer.

With a large immigrant population, France is one of the most ethnically diverse countries in Europe. It is a secular (nonreligious) state. Throughout history, French culture, art, philosophy, literature, and fashion have influenced the rest of the world. It is also the most visited country in the world and its capital, Paris, is considered to be one of the world's most beautiful cities. Many influential artists, writers, and filmmakers of the modern era have lived there.

▼ FRENCH CHATEAU

Chateau de La Brède in Gironde, France, is a castle dating from the early 14th century. Built on a small islet surrounded by water-filled moats, it was the birthplace and residence of the writer and philosopher Montesquieu (1689–1755).

